

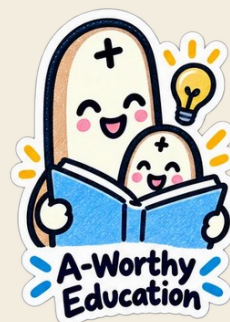


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H1 General Paper: Essay and Comprehension Frameworks

The framework for each essay type and each Paper 2 question, with model paragraphs and the errors each framework prevents.

LEVEL JC 1 and JC 2 · GCE A-Level H1 General Paper (Syllabus 8881)



How to use this guide

Each section names one question type, gives its framework as numbered steps, works an example and lists the errors it prevents. Every framework is the **Hit** step of the SHARP routine we use in class:

S See	H Hit	A Apply	R Refine	P Practise
Read the command word and the scope of the claim.	Pick the framework for that question type.	Build one paragraph or answer at a time.	Check it against the error list.	Rewrite it from memory under timed conditions.

The papers (SEAB 8881). Paper 1: one essay from eight questions, 500 to 800 words, 1 hour 30 minutes, 50 marks (Content 30, Language 20). Paper 2: three passages of about 1200 words in total, 1 hour 30 minutes, 50 marks (Content 35, Language 15, the Language marks based on the summary and the application answer). Paper 2 questions cover Passage 1 (9 to 11 marks), a summary of Passage 2 (8 marks), connections across passages (4 to 6 marks) and an application question (12 marks).

Choosing the essay framework. A question that asks you to defend one position takes thesis-driven P-E-E-L. “Discuss”, “To what extent” and “How far do you agree” demand balance: use balanced P-E-E-L. “Evaluate”, “How successful” and “Assess” demand a standard of judgement: use criteria-led P-E-E-L.

1 Argumentative Essay: Thesis-Driven P-E-E-L

Paper 1 · one clear position, defended with evidence and reasoning

An argumentative question needs a single, clear position. Thesis-driven P-E-E-L states the thesis in the introduction and makes every body paragraph advance it.

Steps

1. Decode the command word and the scope of the claim: all societies, Singapore only, or a period of time?
2. Write a thesis in the introduction that answers the question directly. Do not open with “This essay will discuss”.
3. Build each body paragraph in **P-E-E-L**: a **Point** that advances the thesis; **Evidence** from a named country, policy or outcome; an **Explanation** of why the evidence proves the point; a **Link** back to the thesis.
4. In the penultimate paragraph, take on the strongest opposing position and rebut it with reasons.
5. Conclude with a weighed judgement, not a summary of the paragraphs.

Five ways to open. Concession-pivot: grant the other view, then turn with “yet” (the most versatile). Striking statistic: a real figure that challenges the premise; never invent one. Anecdotal hook: a real event that illustrates the thesis, in two or three sentences. Definition-reframe: test a key term with more than one meaning, such as “success” or “progress”. Provocative claim: contradict the premise in one sentence, then prove it.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Question: “Has technology made us less human?” The same point, before and after.

Before: “Technology has made us less human because we are always on our phones and don’t talk to each other any more.” This is an assertion with no evidence; it is one-sided and never explains why.

After: “Technology can erode genuine connection: many people now spend hours each day on their devices, and research links heavy social-media use to rising loneliness. Yet the same tools reconnect families across continents, so the dehumanising effect is real, but depends on how we use technology rather than on the technology itself.”

In a full essay, replace “research links” with the named study, country or year: the Evidence step asks for a source the examiner can check.

Errors this framework prevents

- A thesis buried in the third paragraph, or no thesis at all.
- Examples with no country, date or outcome.
- Paragraphs that list examples instead of explaining them.
- A counter-argument mentioned and dismissed in one line.

2 Discursive Essay: Balanced P-E-E-L

Paper 1 · “Discuss”, “To what extent...”, “How far do you agree...”

A discursive question sets up a tension and demands balance, not fence-sitting. Balanced P-E-E-L weighs two perspectives by their evidence and ends in a verdict.

Steps

1. Spot the tension: which two perspectives does the question set against each other? Test any absolute word, such as “threat” or “always”.
2. Present perspective A in two P-E-E-L paragraphs.
3. Concede the strongest point of the other side before you counter it.
4. Present perspective B in two equally developed P-E-E-L paragraphs.
5. Conclude with a synthesis: a weighted verdict that says which side carries more weight, and why.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Question: “Science is a threat to humanity. Discuss.” Thesis and one body paragraph (adapted from our model essay).

Thesis: “Science itself is neither benign nor malicious: it is a tool whose impact depends on the institutional and ethical frameworks that govern its use. While science can be misapplied in ways that threaten humanity, it is not inherently a threat; the absence of strong oversight is what turns scientific progress into danger.”

P One of the strongest arguments that science threatens humanity lies in weapons of mass destruction, where scientific knowledge was deliberately channelled towards catastrophic harm.

E The Manhattan Project produced the atomic bombs dropped on Hiroshima and Nagasaki in 1945, and the arms race that followed brought the world to the brink during the Cuban Missile Crisis of 1962.

E The same physics underpins nuclear energy, a source of low-carbon electricity. The threat came from governments’ decision to put military uses first, and from the absence of international rules at the time, not from the physics itself.

L This supports the position that science becomes a threat only when it is divorced from ethical oversight.

Errors this framework prevents

- The counter-view squeezed into a single sentence.
- “Both sides have merit” as the conclusion.
- One perspective developed in depth and the other only sketched.
- A one-sided essay for a question that asks you to discuss.

3 Evaluative Essay: Criteria-Led P-E-E-L

Paper 1 · “Evaluate the effectiveness...”, “How successful...”, “Assess...”

An evaluative question asks you to judge. Criteria-led P-E-E-L names the standard of judgement first and builds each paragraph around it, instead of listing pros and cons.

Steps

1. Find the criterion: evaluate against what standard? Effectiveness, fairness, feasibility, equity or sustainability?
2. Split the key word into criteria: “effective” becomes “effective at what?”
3. Write one P-E-E-L paragraph per criterion, with evidence that measures performance against that yardstick.
4. Deliver a verdict that states the conditions under which your judgement holds.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Question: “Has Singapore’s education system been effective?” Effective at what?

Criterion (one paragraph each)	What the paragraph’s evidence must measure
Academic outcomes	Results against a stated benchmark, with a named source and year.
Social mobility	Whether students from lower-income homes progress, with a named study or policy.
Holistic development	What the system develops beyond examinations, with named programmes and their outcomes.

Verdict pattern: “Effective on [criterion] because...; less effective on [criterion] unless...”. A verdict that specifies its conditions is a judgement; “it depends” is not.

Errors this framework prevents

- A list of pros and cons with no yardstick.
- “It depends” as the verdict.
- Criteria named in the introduction and then dropped in the body.

4 SAQ Comprehension: Quote + Explain

Paper 2 · short-answer questions on Passage 1 (9 to 11 marks in total)

Short-answer questions reward precision, not volume. Quote + Explain has two moves: find the words that hold the answer, then explain them in your own words without losing any of their meaning.

Steps

1. Identify the question type: literal, inference, vocabulary in context, or the author’s craft.
2. **Quote** the phrase from the passage that contains the answer.
3. **Explain** what the phrase means in context, in your own words.
4. For inference, go beyond the surface meaning to the author’s stance. For vocabulary, give the meaning in this passage, not the dictionary meaning.
5. Match ideas to marks: a 2-mark question needs two distinct ideas, not one idea said twice.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Passage (illustrative): “Our cities now sell their skylines to tourists while the people who built them are priced out of the neighbourhoods they grew up in.” What does the author imply about how cities treat their residents? [2]

Answer: The phrase “sell their skylines to tourists” shows that cities market their appearance to visitors for profit (**idea 1**). Residents are “priced out” of their own neighbourhoods, so rising costs force them to leave (**idea 2**). The author implies that cities value tourist income above the people who live in them.

Errors this framework prevents

- An explanation that repeats the author's words.
- One idea given twice in different words for a 2-mark question.
- A dictionary definition for a vocabulary-in-context question.
- A surface paraphrase where the question asks what the author implies.

5 Summary: Content Point List + Paraphrase Chain

Paper 2 · summary of Passage 2 · 8 marks · also counts towards the Language marks

Examiners penalise lifting and reward concision. The method has three steps: list the points, paraphrase each one by restructuring, then chain them within the word limit.

Steps

1. Number every content point in the relevant part of the passage: every distinct idea the examiner could credit.
2. Paraphrase each point by restructuring the sentence: change the word class, reorder the clauses, or switch between active and passive. Do not rely on swapping single words.
3. Chain the paraphrased points into compound sentences to stay within the word limit.
4. Cut padding: examples, hedges and filler words.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Source (illustrative, 26 words): "The destruction of the forest was rapid. It removed the habitat of many species. It also increased the risk of flooding in the villages nearby."

Point list: (1) the forest was destroyed quickly; (2) many species lost their habitat; (3) nearby villages became more likely to flood.

Chain (18 words): "The forest was cleared quickly, leaving many species without a habitat and exposing nearby villages to more floods." The noun "destruction" became a verb, and three sentences became one.

Errors this framework prevents

- Lifting phrases from the passage.
- Synonym swaps that keep the author's sentence structure.
- Running over the word limit, or spending words on examples.

6 Application Question: AQ Response Template

Paper 2 · 12 marks · also counts towards the Language marks

The application question rewards thinking beyond the passage, not summarising it. The template has four moves. Keep a Singapore Context File and add to it every week from the news.

Steps

1. **State** each author's core claim in one precise sentence.
2. **Evaluate** it: agree, disagree, or agree with qualifications, and give the reason.
3. **Apply** the claim to a Singapore-specific context, with evidence.
4. **Add your own voice:** a perspective informed by knowledge the authors do not address.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Author's claim (illustrative): "Traditions survive only when governments protect them."

- 1 The author argues that state protection is the condition for a tradition's survival.
- 2 I agree only in part: protection helps, but it cannot replace the people who practise a tradition.
- 3 Singapore nominated its hawker culture, and UNESCO inscribed it on its list of intangible cultural heritage in 2020. The recognition raised its profile, yet a stall still closes when its hawker retires without a successor.
- 4 In my view, a tradition in Singapore lasts when young people see a livelihood in it; state recognition is the start, not the guarantee.

Errors this framework prevents

- Summarising the passage instead of evaluating it.
- Generic examples with no Singapore context.
- Agreeing or disagreeing without a reason.
- No perspective beyond the authors' own.

Summary: every framework on one page

Question type	Framework	Steps
Paper 1 · Argumentative	Thesis-driven P-E-E-L	Decode command and scope; thesis in the introduction; Point, Evidence (named), Explanation, Link in each paragraph; rebut the strongest opposing view; weighed conclusion.
Paper 1 · Discursive	Balanced P-E-E-L	Spot the tension; perspective A in two paragraphs; concede the other side's strongest point; perspective B in two paragraphs; weighted verdict.
Paper 1 · Evaluative	Criteria-led P-E-E-L	Name the criterion; split the key word into criteria; one P-E-E-L paragraph per criterion; verdict with conditions.
Paper 1 · Introduction	Five openings	Concession-pivot, striking statistic (real only), anecdotal hook, definition-reframe, provocative claim.
Paper 2 · SAQ	Quote + Explain	Name the question type; quote the phrase; explain it in context in your own words; one distinct idea per mark.
Paper 2 · Summary	Content Point List + Paraphrase Chain	Number every point; paraphrase by restructuring; chain into compound sentences; cut padding; stay within the limit.
Paper 2 · Application	AQ Response Template	State each author's claim; evaluate it; apply it to Singapore with evidence; add your own voice.

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